# Introduction to Psychology (PSYC-SHU 101)

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# Experimental Discovery 2

# NYU Shanghai

**Group number:** 6

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**Research question:** Does being unfairly treated by a friend or by a stranger trigger more anger?

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## Introduction

In this study, we analyse how interpersonal relationships impact individuals' assessment of morality and their level of anger in response to being treated unfairly in a hypothetical scenario. Moral injury is a term that can be described as a lasting impact resulting from perpetrating, experiencing, or witnessing acts that defy deeply held moral beliefs and expectations (Phelps, et al., 2021). The scenario we present is a low-risk situation that is still enough to elicit feelings of anger and moral frustration. By assessing the impact of interpersonal relationships, we may better predict the possibility of moral injury.

## Research question and hypotheses

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Research question: Does being unfairly treated by a friend or by a stranger trigger more anger? Null hypothesis: There will be no significant difference in anger ratings between participants who are treated unfairly by a friend or a stranger. Experimental hypothesis: Participants will report higher anger ratings when treated unfairly by a friend rather than by a stranger.

## Method

### Participants

The survey consisted of 14 males, 29 females, and 1 person who refused to identify, with 20 and 24 respondents for the FRIEND and STRANGER scenarios, excluding those who answered the concentration question incorrectly. Average age of the participants: 19

### Materials

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The platform Qualtrics was used to create the survey in which the participants were presented randomly with one of two scenarios that occurred in the workplace. The slight difference for the IV is whether Jason was a friend or a stranger of the participant.

## Measures

This study employed two primary dependent variables to capture the emotional and evaluative responses of participants to the scenario: Anger and Moral Judgment.

1. The Level of Anger – Question: "How angry would you feel after what happened in the scenario?". This was rated on an 11-point single-item scale ranging from 0 (Not angry at all) to 10 (Very angry). 2. Morality of the situation – Question: "How would you rate the moral character of [friend/stranger]?" This was rated on an 11-point single-item scale ranging from -5 (Very immoral) to +5 (Very moral) with 0 being neutral.

## Procedure

The participants were asked to give their consent after reading and agreeing to the Research Study Consent Form. In the survey, they needed to provide brief, non-identifying personal information first, and then they were presented a story of being unfairly treated by a stranger or friend in the workplace. Each of these groups are randomly chosen for each participant. After that, they need to rate their level of anger and the morality of the situation. Finally, to ensure the validity of their response, they were asked a concentration question.

## Results

### Descriptive results

Figure 1: The anger and morality level of each condition

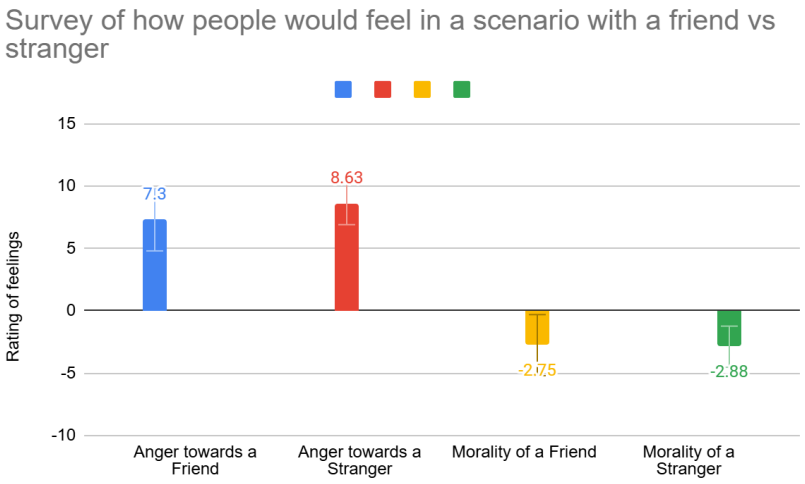


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Figure 1 indicates that being unfairly treated by friends triggers slightly less anger and is less immoral than being treated by strangers, with a small variation.

## Discussion

### Main discussion

The study aimed to examine how people react emotionally to unfair treatment by friends versus strangers. As shown in Figure 1, unfair treatment by friends wouldn't trigger greater anger, contrasting our hypothesis and indicating that strangers' unfairness might feel more unjustified, while that from friends may be rationalized. These findings refine our understanding of emotional responses in social contexts, showing that relational closeness does not always intensify anger. Future research could test how attribution and trust influence these reactions.

### Limitations

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Participants may think being angry is socially unacceptable which may cause their responses to be biased. In this case, their levels of anger would be lower than what they truly feel since it allows them to appear more tamed. Additionally, a few participants were already aware of the experimental hypothesis in advance, which may have led to biased responses in the data. Lastly, it is hard for people to define their anger as a number since they aren't currently in the situation that is presented to them.

### Conclusion

Overall, the findings indicate that unfair treatment by strangers evokes more anger than unfair treatment by friends, contrary to our initial hypothesis. This suggests that anger may be driven more by perceived hostility and social distance than by violated expectations within

close relationships. The study highlights that emotional responses to unfairness depend on context and social dynamics, contributing to a deeper understanding of how relationship factors influence moral and emotional judgment.

**References**

Adler, A. B., & Forbes, D. (Eds.). (2021). Anger at work: Prevention, intervention, and treatment in high-risk occupations. American Psychological Association. https://doi.org/10.1037/0000244-000